night-enabled cameras and other specialised equipment.

But too much blood was being spilt, and the vortex of violence was sucking in the civilian population. One that had played a crucial role in turning the tide against the first wave of militancy here between the mid-'90s and 2007, with the local Muslims joining armed village defence committees. No wonder Topa Peer, a hamlet of some 30 houses, is still seized with shocked disbelief. A day after the December 21 ambush, nine of its men were picked up by 48 Rashtriya Rifles. Three—Safeer Ahmad (45), Mohammad Showkat (26) and Shabir Ahmad (30)—were later found on the road, very dead and bearing marks of torture. Five are in hospital. A video released on social media seemed to point to RR soldiers from the nearby camp. Compensations followed. But Mohammad Sideeq, Topa Peer panch and Showkat's uncle, says, "We want justice. What was the fault of our children? Give us reason for snatching them from us."

The news triggered such waves of condemnation that Union defence minister Rajnath Singh dropped by, along with army chief Gen. Manoj Pande. Three officers, including a brigadier, were moved out; a court of inquiry was set up; the J&K Police filed a case against unknown individuals. Union home minister Amit Shah, too, was slated to meet the bereaved families, after a security review in Jammu—till bad weather delayed his plan. Clearly, the Centre isn't about to make light of this spiral of instability in a new hotspot.

As 2024 dawned, New Delhi took stock. The November-December actions hadn't come out of the blue. October 2021 had broken a long peace in Jammu's three mountainous districts with what proved to be the longest-ever operation in Poonch: nine armymen, including two junior commissioned officers, were killed. Thereafter, attacks and ambushes on security forces never really slackened. And it picked up last year. Since January '23, at least 52 people, including 25 security personnel and 25 terrorists, have been killed here. In all, since October '21, security forces had killed around 30, mostly Pakistani terrorists, but also lost about 30 men, including officers, in Poonch, Reasi and Rajouri. After analysing the pattern of encounters, the army now feels two small groups of Lashkar-e-Toiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed militants are the deadliest. One group, with just two members, is thought to be responsible for Poonch '21 and also the August '22 ambush in the army's Pargal camp in Rajouri that killed four soldiers. The other, with some five men, is led by a highly trained commander adept at guerrilla tactics and is deemed responsible for all attacks thereafter, including the latest one in Dehra ki Gali. Overall, agencies suspect the active presence of around 15-25 Pakistani terrorists in the sector.

TAKEAWAYS

- **25 securitymen and 25 terrorists have been killed in Jammu's three mountain districts since Jan. '23**
- **Porous borders, lower troop presence make these high-altitude forests a magnet for militants**
- **The death of three locals due to alleged army torture has stoked anger in the area**

With blanket security cover only getting denser in the Valley, infiltrating terrorists have evidently revived the two-decade-old route towards the less militarised heights of the Pir Panjal. Close to 200 terrorists are estimated to be in launch pads across the LoC; they make a slow trickle regulated by strategic needs and the winter snow. "Rajouri, Poonch and Reasi have porous borders, and they take advantage of gaps in the fencing," says an army official. Natural caves in these forests also offer perfect hideouts. What has aided their reoccupation after a long gap is the arrival of drones, a handy tool for reconnoitering and supply/replenishing of weapons.

The terrorist diffusion over this map came at a time when military planners were reducing the number of units of its elite counter-insurgency force Rashtriya Rifles, moving some towards Eastern Ladakh after the 2020 Galwan Valley clash. The reduced RR units stretched existing forces, who now had larger areas to man, giving militants gaps to exploit. This strategic finesse lends weight to a supplementary theory: that they are no solo musketeers. Lt Gen. Upendra Dwivedi, commander of the Udhampur-based Northern Command, voiced it when he spoke of the possible presence of retired Pakistani soldiers among the terrorist corps. On the other side of the Pir Panjal, between September 13 and 20, the picture-postcard prettiness of Kokernag in Kashmir's Anantnag too had been bloodied by a week-long operation. Again, it was at the cost of four security personnel, including a colonel, a major and a deputy superintendent of police, that two terrorists were slain. But on the whole, the strategic battleground has shifted.

Disturbingly, what this announces emphatically is the spectre of militancy returning to J&K, complete with its 'spread' effect: targeted Hindu killings, custodial deaths, civilian anger. That last is the one the Centre can do without. As former Northern Army commander Lt Gen. Deependra Singh Hooda (retd) says, the support of local Gujjar and Bakerwal herders, who shift to highland pastures in summer, is essential for combating terrorism—it is they who spot the fugitive tracks. Remember, it was a shepherd who had spotted the infiltration at Kargil? ■